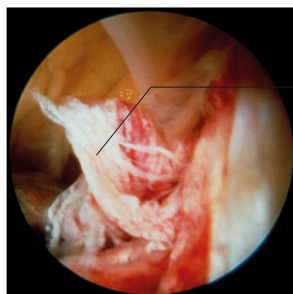


LIGAMENT INJURIES

Ligaments are strong, flexible bands of fibrous tissue that link bone ends together around a joint. If the bones in a joint are pulled too far apart, often as a result of a sudden or forceful movement, the ligament fibres may overstretch or tear. This commonly results in swelling, pain, and muscle spasm. A joint “sprain” is usually due to partial tearing of a ligament. Rest, ice,

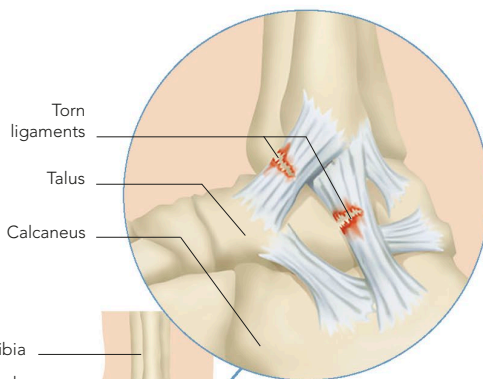
compression, and elevation of the joint is the usual treatment if a sprain is not serious. A severe injury may result in joint instability or dislocation.



Anterior cruciate ligament

LIGAMENT FIBRES

This view through an arthroscope (a telescope-like tube for seeing into joints) reveals torn fibres of a knee's anterior cruciate ligament.



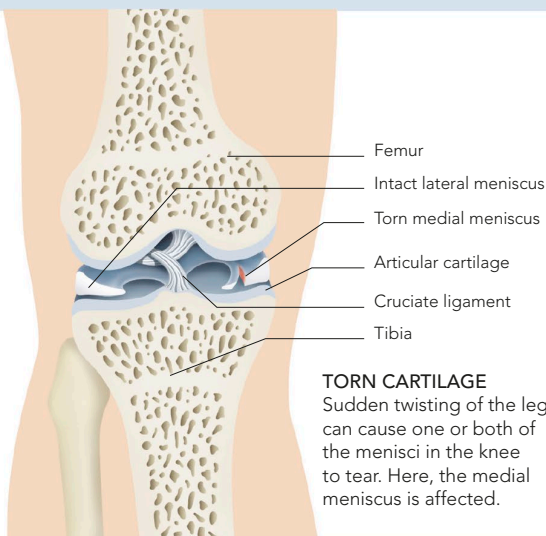
Tibia
Fibula
Navicular

SPRAINED ANKLE

The ligaments in the ankle may be sprained if a fall forces the weight of the body on to the outer edge of the foot.

TORN CARTILAGE

The knee joint contains pad-like, curved “discs” of cartilage called menisci. These are almost C-shaped and made of tough fibrous cartilage. The discs are situated between the lower end of the femur and upper end of the tibia, with the medial meniscus on the knee's inner side and the lateral meniscus on the outside. These discs stabilize the joint, helping it to “lock” straight while standing, and cushion the bones. A meniscus may be crushed or torn by rapid twisting of the knee, often while playing sport. If such an injury is painful, surgery can remove the damaged piece of cartilage.



TORN CARTILAGE

Sudden twisting of the leg can cause one or both of the menisci in the knee to tear. Here, the medial meniscus is affected.